

compositions published when he was seven, and made his public debut as a performer when he was eight. Soon he had a reputation as a boy wonder.

Early successes

From 1826 to 1829, Chopin studied at the Warsaw Academy of Music, where his final report described him as a “musical genius.” He had indeed already shown remarkable gifts as a composer and pianist. The most important compositions of his youth are his two piano concertos, both written by the time he was 20. He was the soloist at their first performances, in Warsaw’s National Theater in March and October 1830. They won great acclaim, but Warsaw was considered provincial in musical terms and Chopin was already thinking beyond Poland. He had briefly visited Berlin in 1828 and Vienna in 1829, and in November 1830, following the success of his piano concertos, he set out to make a longer stay in Vienna—the musical capital of Europe.

**“Mold the keyboard with a velvet hand and
feel the key rather than striking it.”**

FREDERIC CHOPIN (ADVICE TO HIS PUPILS)